

List of Phonetic Symbols

- 📖 *The need for phonetic symbols – lack of a one-to-one correspondence between letters of the alphabet and the sounds they represent in several languages, including English.*
- 📖 *The variety or dialect of English chosen for this study.*
- 📖 *The sounds of Educated Southern British English – consonants.*
- 📖 *The sounds of Educated Southern British English – vowels.*
- 📖 *The IPA chart and brief descriptions of the symbols included in the chart.*

(A) NEED FOR PHONETIC SYMBOLS

In this book we are going to deal with *language*. Most of the examples given to illustrate a point will be from English, some Indian languages and Arabic. When we refer to a particular **SOUND** of English, we shall use a **PHONETIC SYMBOL** from the **INTERNATIONAL PHONETIC ALPHABET** (or the **ALPHABET OF THE INTERNATIONAL PHONETIC ASSOCIATION – IPA for short.**)

Before we list the various phonetic symbols, let us discuss *why* we should use phonetic symbols at all. Most languages have letters of the alphabet which literate users of the language have mastered. Why should we learn additional symbols? There *is* need for learning phonetic symbols and using them *because in several languages there is no one-to-one correspondence between letters of the alphabet and the sounds they represent*. Let us illustrate this from English. For example, let us take the first letter of the English alphabet, the letter < a > . In the words *hat, hate, part, want* and *caught* the letter < a > occurs. But in British English this letter is *pronounced in FIVE different ways in these five words*. The same sound (the sound that begins the English word *shine*) occurs in the words

sheep, sugar, machine, pressure and nation. In each of these words, the sound is *spelt differently* (with the letters <sh>, <s>, <ch>, <ss> and <ti> respectively). There are several other examples that one can cite, but these two examples prove that in English, by looking at a word in its *spelling form*, we can't be sure about its *pronunciation*. If we can write down words using an alphabet in which *one symbol always represents the same sound*, it will be easy to ascertain the pronunciation of words. That is why we are introducing you to a set of new symbols and these are the symbols used by the *International Phonetic Association* (abbreviated to *IPA*). It is also referred to as the *IPA alphabet*.

(B) THE VARIETY OF ENGLISH CHOSEN

In the following pages, the phonetic symbols used for the sounds of English have been listed. You are advised to go through them carefully and become familiar with them. There are different varieties of English like British English, American English, Australian English, etc. Even within British English, there are different varieties or *dialects* like London English (also called *cockney* (the kind of English Eliza Doolittle speaks in Bernard Shaw's famous play *Pygmalion* before she receives training in speech from Professor Higgins), Scottish English, etc. The pronunciation that has been chosen for description in this book is one of the varieties of *British English*. This variety of English is often referred to as *Received Pronunciation*, abbreviated to *R.P.*

On the list that follows, all the individual consonant symbols have been given within square brackets – [], but in the word cited to illustrate the occurrence of the sound represented by each symbol, the phonetic symbols have been given *within two slant lines* like / / (e.g., *beat* = /bi:t/). The difference between writing a symbol within square brackets [] and slant lines / / will become clear when you learn *PHONOLOGY*.

The Sounds of British English (R.P.) – Consonants

1. [p] as in the word	<i>spoon</i>	/spu:n/
2. [b] as in the word	<i>beat</i>	/bi:t/
3. [t] as in the word	<i>stem</i>	/stem/
4. [d] as in the word	<i>dean</i>	/di:n/
5. [k] as in the word	<i>school</i>	/sku:l/
6. [g] as in the word	<i>good</i>	/gud/

7. [tʃ] as in the word
8. [dʒ] as in the word
9. [m] as in the word
10. [n] as in the word
11. [ŋ] as in the word
12. [f] as in the word
13. [v] as in the word
14. [θ] as in the word
15. [ð] as in the word
16. [s] as in the word
17. [z] as in the word
18. [ʃ] as in the word
19. [ʒ] as in the word
20. [h] as in the word
21. [l] as in the word
22. [r] as in the word
23. [j] as in the word
24. [w] as in the word

<i>teach</i>	/ti:tʃ/
<i>June</i>	/dʒu:n/
<i>mean</i>	/mi:n/
<i>neat</i>	/ni:t/
<i>finger</i>	/ˈfɪŋɡə/ ¹
<i>feet</i>	/fi:t/
<i>vest</i>	/vest/
<i>three</i>	/θri:/
<i>these</i>	/ði:z/
<i>seat</i>	/si:t/
<i>zoo</i>	/zu:/
<i>sheet</i>	/ʃi:t/
<i>leisure</i>	/ˈleɪʒə/ ¹
<i>heat</i>	/hi:t/
<i>leave</i>	/li:v/
<i>rest</i>	/rest/
<i>yes</i>	/jes/
<i>west</i>	/west/

The Sounds of British English (R.P.) – (Vowels)

1. /i:/ as in the word	<i>seat</i>	/si:t/
2. /ɪ/ as in the word	<i>sit</i>	/sɪt/
3. /e/ as in the word	<i>bed</i>	/bed/
4. /æ/ as in the word	<i>bad</i>	/bæd/
5. /ɑ:/ as in the word	<i>past</i>	/pɑ:st/
6. /ɒ/ as in the word	<i>lost</i>	/lɒst/
7. /ɔ:/ as in the word	<i>saw</i>	/sɔ:/
8. /u:/ as in the word	<i>two</i>	/tu:/
9. /ʊ/ as in the word	<i>put</i>	/put/

¹ The mark ¹ before a syllable indicates that the syllable that comes immediately after the mark is **stressed** or **strong** or **accented**. You will learn more about the phenomenon of **word-accent** in a later Chapter.

10. /ʌ/ as in the word	cut	/kʌt/
11. /ɜ:/ as in the word	girl	/gɜ:l/
12. /ə/ as in the word	father	/'fɑ:ðə/ (The, Us second syllable)
13. /eɪ/ as in the word	late, play	/leɪt/
14. /aɪ/ as in the word	light	/laɪt/
15. /ɔɪ/ as in the word	boy	/bɔɪ/
16. /aʊ/ as in the word	cow, town	/kaʊ/
17. /əʊ/ as in the word	coat, slow, dough	/kəʊt/
18. /ɪə/ as in the word	hear	/hɪə/
19. /ʊə/ as in the word	tour	/tʊə/
20. /eə/ as in the word	where	/weə/ (Pain, Pear)

The forty-four symbols listed above are used to represent the sounds that occur in one variety of English. The International Phonetic Alphabet (often abbreviated to IPA) has symbols for all the sounds that are used in all the languages of the world. The IPA chart has been reproduced at the end of this book. Listed below are the phonetic symbols of the sounds you are likely to come across and use in your everyday life. Let us now describe each symbol, that is, give a descriptive label of the sound each symbol represents, with an illustrative example from English, an Indian language or Arabic. No illustrative example is given in the case of certain sounds that don't occur in English or the better-known Indian languages.

All the sounds that are described here are articulated with the air that goes out of our lungs. There are a few sounds which are articulated with the help of air other than the air we breathe out. These sounds don't occur in English or the major Indian languages (some of them do occur in Sindhi, a language used by people in India and Pakistan) and the symbols representing these sounds are not described below.

Consonant Sounds:

- [p] Voiceless bilabial plosive as in the English word *spin*, Hindi प, Tamil ப in the word பால் (= *milk*)
- [p^h] Aspirated voiceless bilabial plosive as in English *appear*, Hindi फ
- [b] Voiced bilabial plosive, as in English *box*, Hindi ब, Tamil ப as in இன்பம் (= *pleasure*)

- [bʱ] Breathy voiced bilabial plosive (traditionally called *voiced aspirated bilabial plosive*, but it is more accurate to call it *breathy voiced* instead of *voiced aspirated*). Hindi ब. **தாய்** (= *mother*).
- [t̪] Voiceless denti-alveolar plosive, Hindi त, Tamil த as in **தாய்** (= *mother*).
- [t̪ʰ] Aspirated voiceless denti-alveolar plosive, Hindi थ.
- [d̪] Voiced denti-alveolar plosive, Hindi द, Tamil த as in **கந்தல்** (= *rags*).
- [d̪ʱ] Breathy voiced denti-alveolar plosive, Hindi ध.
- [t̪] Voiceless alveolar plosive, as in English *stand*.
- [t̪ʰ] Aspirated voiceless alveolar plosive, as in English *contain*.
- [d̪] Voiced alveolar plosive, as in English *do*.
- [d̪ʱ] Breathy voiced alveolar plosive.
- [c] Voiceless palatal plosive, Hindi च.
- [cʰ] Aspirated voiceless palatal plosive, Hindi छ.
- [ɟ] Voiced palatal plosive, Hindi ज.
- [ɟʱ] Breathy voiced palatal plosive, Hindi झ.
- [ɖ] Voiceless retroflex plosive, Hindi ढ, Tamil ட as in **பாட்டி** (= *grandmother*).
- [ɖʰ] Aspirated voiceless retroflex plosive, Hindi ढ.
- [ɖ̪] Voiced retroflex plosive, Hindi ढ. Tamil ட as in **நண்டு** (= *crab*).
- [ɖ̪ʱ] Breathy voiced retroflex plosive, Hindi ढ.
- [k] Voiceless velar plosive, as in English *skin*, Tamil க as in **கல்** (= *stone*) Hindi क.
- [kʰ] Aspirated voiceless velar plosive, as in English *culture*, Hindi ख.
- [ɡ] Voiced velar plosive, as in English *girl*, Hindi ग, Tamil க as in **தங்கம்** (= *gold*).
- [ɡʱ] Breathy voiced velar plosive, Hindi घ.
- [q] Voiceless uvular plosive, Urdu/Arabic <ق>
- [qʰ] Aspirated voiceless uvular plosive.
- [ɢ] Voiced uvular plosive.
- [ɢʱ] Breathy voiced uvular plosive.
- [ʔ] Glottal plosive or glottal stop. (Arabic "*hamza*")
- [tʃ] Voiceless palato-alveolar affricate, as in English *chin*.
- [dʒ] Voiced palato-alveolar affricate, as in English *just*.
- [m] Voiced bilabial nasal, as in English *moon*, Hindi म, Tamil ம.

- [m] Voiced labio-dental nasal as the < *m* > in the English word *comfort*.
- [ɱ] Voiced dental/denti-alveolar nasal, Hindi न before त or द, Tamil ற before த as in தந்தி (= telegram).
- [n] Voiced alveolar nasal, as in English *nice*. Tamil ன as in மான் (= *deer*), Hindi न.
- [ɲ] Voiced palatal nasal, Hindi ण, Tamil ன்.
- [ɳ] Voiced retroflex nasal, Hindi ण Tamil ண்.
- [ŋ] Voiced velar nasal, as in English *uncle*, Hindi ङ, Tamil ன்.
- [ʌ] Voiced uvular nasal.
- [ɸ] Voiceless bilabial fricative.
- [β] Voiced bilabial fricative.
- [f] Voiceless labio-dental fricative, as in English *five*.
- [v] Voiced labio-dental fricative, as in English *van*.
- [θ] Voiceless dental fricative, as in English *thin*. Arabic < ث >.
- [ð] Voiced dental fricative, as in English *then*, Arabic ذ.
- [s] Voiceless alveolar fricative, as in English *six*, Hindi स, Tamil ஸ.
- [z] Voiced alveolar fricative, as in English *zoo*.
- [ʃ] Voiceless palato-alveolar fricative, as in English *ship*.
- [ʒ] Voiced palato-alveolar fricative, as in English *pleasure*.
- [ʂ] Voiceless retroflex fricative, Hindi ष before ट, Tamil ஷ.
- [ʐ] Voiced retroflex fricative.
- [ç] Voiceless alveolo-palatal fricative.
- [ʒ] Voiced alveolo-palatal fricative.
- [ç] Voiceless palatal fricative.
- [j] Voiced palatal fricative (the same symbol is used to represent the semi-vowel sound that begins the English word *you*).
- [x] Voiceless velar fricative.
- [ɣ] Voiced velar fricative.
- [χ] Voiceless uvular fricative, Urdu/ Arabic, < خ >.
- [ʁ] Voiced uvular fricative, Urdu /Arabic < غ >.
- [ħ] Voiceless pharyngeal fricative, Urdu/Arabic < ح >.
- [ʕ] Voiced pharyngeal fricative.
- [h] Voiceless glottal fricative, as in English *hat*, Hindi ह, Tamil ஹ.

- [ɦ] Voiced glottal fricative, as the letter < h > in English *behind*, *beehive*.
- [ʋ] Voiced labio-dental approximant (or frictionless continuant), Hindi व, Tamil வ.
- [ɹ] Voiced post-alveolar approximant (or frictionless continuant), the letter < r > in English *read*, *road* in R.P.
- [ɻ] Voiced retroflex approximant (or frictionless continuant), Tamil ழ.
- [j] Voiced palatal approximant (or semi-vowel), as in English *you*, Hindi य, Tamil ய.
- [w] Voiced labial-velar approximant (or semi-vowel), as in English *west*.